

CHRONOLOGY OF EVENTS

1995 The Department of Biotechnology (DBT) permits import of 100 gm of transgenic Cocker-312 variety of cottonseed cultivated in the US by Mahyco.

1998 Monsanto-Mahyco tie up. Monsanto is given permission for small trials of Bt cotton. DBT grants permission for trials at numerous locations. Farmers protest as trials are underway without permission of regional governments and without consent of local communities.

1999 Vandana Shiva's Research Foundation for Science, Technology and Ecology goes to the Supreme Court challenging the "illegality" of the field trials authorised by the DBT.

2000 GEAC clears Mahyco to conduct large-scale field trials, including seed production at 40 sites in six states.

2001 GEAC extends field trials of Bt cotton by another year. Mahyco conducts large-scale trials on 100 hectares in seven states. In October, it begins commercial Bt cotton farming over several thousand hectares in Gujarat. Evaluation to study growth, development and efficacy of Bt brinjal begins.

2002 DBT declares the latest round of Bt cotton trials as satisfactory and says it is up to the GEAC and the ministry to decide on a date of commercial release. GEAC approves Bt cotton.

2003 Confined field trials to study pollen flow, germination, aggressiveness and weediness; biochemical, toxicity and allergenicity studies and backcrossing into the regular breeding programme in Bt brinjal.

2005 Trials of Bt brinjal begin at TNAU, Coimbatore and UAS, Dharwad.

2006 GEAC posts the bio-safety data on Bt brinjal given by Mahyco on its website; constitutes a sub-committee to look into the concerns raised by civil society. Supreme Court stops ongoing trials of GM crops due to a PIL filed by civil society representatives.



ACTIVISTS PROTESTING AGAINST THE COMMERCIAL PRODUCTION OF Bt BRINJAL

2007 The expert committee recommends that more studies on biosafety be repeated but gives a green signal for large scale trials. Supreme Court lifts ban on GM crop field trials subject to conditions.

2009 Due to concerns raised by experts, GEAC constitutes a second sub-committee to look into adequacy of biosafety data, on the basis of which GEAC approves the environmental release of Bt brinjal. Fresh outcry makes Jairam Ramesh announce nation-wide consultations.

the crop and the negative impact on human and animal health are cleared.

The manner in which Ramesh gave his verdict has fuelled speculation that the controversial GM vegetable has effectively been banned. Now farmers, who face a grim battle against pests to grow the traditional varieties, will have to wait longer or perhaps endlessly for Bt brinjal. If one goes by the Bt cotton experience, the apprehensions of illegal cultivation of transgenic brinjal can't be ruled out.

For the Government and Ramesh, it became a Hobson's choice in the absence of an advanced, effective and transparent system that is independ-

ent and conducts safety tests in a manner that engenders public trust. The decision questions the validity of the GEAC which has a mandate to study and approve all transgenic research in the country. What's surprising is that Ramesh waited first for the approval of the GEAC and exposed the establishment's own weaknesses. It didn't have to go through all that it did to confirm that the testing process and the data derived, on whose basis the GEAC gave its go-ahead for commercialisation, are not independent. Much of the data on which GEAC relied was generated by the GM companies themselves.

In such a scenario, the Government should have been in no hurry to rush